

year. Her aides claim that she wants to be in a position where she can take on the Left Government single-handedly and form the government without too much baggage.

For the time being, she has reportedly assured the prime minister that she has no plans of pulling out of the alliance. Her attack, however, is seen as cover for her own absences from the Capital, especially from several cabinet meetings that, in turn, have delayed many crucial decisions. Sources close to Banerjee say that her cabinet colleagues used to complain earlier that she held up the meetings and simply decided to stay away.

Barely two months in office, Banerjee raised objections to the Government's Land Acquisition (Amendment) Bill, 2007, and Rehabilitation and Resettlement Bill at a cabinet meeting. She denounced the provisions of the bill publicly, forcing the Government on the backfoot and the bill on the backburner. But Banerjee has gone ahead with her own land acquisition policy for the Railways. She has instructed her officials to convince and negotiate with the farmers, and only then acquire the land. Banerjee has also promised one railway job for each family which sells the land, something that officials at Rail Bhavan believe is not feasible. Her land acquisition policy has already evinced protests from some states, including Gujarat, with the state Government complaining to the prime minister about delays in projects. Gujarat has never had an issue with land acquisition and work on railway projects has always proceeded smoothly.

Some Congress leaders feel that Banerjee is using her Railways portfolio not only to secure the chief minister's chair in West Bengal but also to settle petty political scores. Her much publicised White Paper, questioning her predecessor Lalu Prasad Yadav's claims of a Railways' turnaround, caused much embarrassment to the

Danger Signals

Manmohan on what ails the Railways and what needs to be done

■ Railway planning is not guided by a clear vision of where the Railways should be 10 to 20 years from now. It should fix specific targets.

■ GDP growth of 9% requires total transport to grow at 10% per year. Railways are growing at only 7%, leading to a steady loss of freight to roads. Railways' share is only an abnormally low 30%.



■ Globally, passenger trains reaching 240 kmph are common but the average speed of our Shatabdi is 80 kmph.

■ The next budget must include a minimum increase of 10 to 15% in second class passenger fare with no increase in freight. The unbalanced fare structure has several adverse consequences.

■ The ministry has been told to avoid land acquisition and "negotiate" with farmers. This needs to be resolved soon to avoid long delays.

■ A decision on the role of Public-Private Partnerships is urgently needed. The ministry has been reluctant to adopt it.

■ Immediate review of the status of Dedicated Freight Corridor with clear timelines and fixing responsibility.

Government. After all, Lalu was part of the first UPA Government and seen as one of the performing ministers. Apparently, the PMO had to cajole her to remove certain passages from the White Paper. "She questioned the need to set up a wheel and axle plant in Chhapra, Lalu's constituency, saying it was unnecessary and awarded at high cost. She was asked to remove it since the project had the sanction and approval of the Planning Commission," says a government official.

Approval of the Planning Commission is not something that she herself can boast of as Banerjee has announced several projects in her state without the requisite sanctions. She has announced an auto hub and a goods yard at Shalimar in Kolkata without any approval or cost estimate. She also plans to set up a coach manufacturing factory in Singur, but again without any survey or approval. Going by her White Paper, she wants to lay down 2,500 km of new railway line every year, with a target of 25,000 km by 2020.

Railway officials claim that without any reference to source of funds or delivery mechanism, the minister will find it impossible to fulfil the promises. "Probably, she doesn't really intend to do it. By 2011, she hopes to be the chief minister of West Bengal, bidding goodbye to the Railway Ministry," says a source in the Congress camp.

The Centre is losing its patience with Banerjee as she goes about her populist politics. "She is like a loose cannon with only the Writer's Building in sight," says an official. The rift is widening. What makes her thrive as the tantrum queen of the Manmohan Cabinet is her mass base in the shrinking citadels of the Marxists in Bengal. She knows that the Congress needs her to oust the 32-year-old Left regime in Kolkata. The UPA Government is fast realising that keeping Banerjee in good humour is costing it a lot—both politically and economically. ■